

Canon Protestant 66

doc-canon-protestant-66

Bibliology · Canon · doctrine · divided_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject covered by a category in Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

The Christian canon comprises the 39 Hebrew Old Testament books and the 27 New Testament books.

In plain language

The biblical texts never state a number like sixty six. What they do is mark a category and two boundaries. In Luke 24 verse 44 the risen Jesus names the older Scriptures under three headings, the Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms (in Greek, 'law' is *nomos*, 'prophet' is *prophētēs*, 'psalm' is *psalmos*). That three part naming matches the Jewish way of arranging the older books, with Psalms heading the third section. In Luke 11 verse 51 Jesus marks a span of murdered righteous from Abel (Habel) in Genesis to a Zechariah killed by the altar (*thysiaστήριον*), whose death is recorded in 2 Chronicles 24. Because the Hebrew arrangement begins with Genesis and ends with 2 Chronicles, this span works like a bracket around the older collection (a figure that names extremes to mean the whole), and both endpoint verses are real Old Testament verses. In Romans 3 verse 2 Paul says the oracles (*logia*, plural of *logion*) of God were entrusted to the Jewish people, which points to the line that kept the Hebrew books. On the newer side, 2 Peter 3 verse 16 puts Paul's letters (*epistolai*, plural of *epistolē*) in the same category as the rest of the writings (*loipas graphas*, the rest of the *graphai*), using the ordinary word for Scripture (*graphē*), and 1 Timothy 5 verse 18 introduces a saying that matches Luke with the words 'the Scripture says' (*legei hē graphē*), so a Gospel line is treated as Scripture. So the words give a category, called writing or Scripture (*graphē*), and they mark a Hebrew bracket on the older side and a letter and Gospel category on the newer side. Here is why readers still divide. The texts list divisions and a span, not a numbered list, and they use open words like 'the rest' (*loipas*), so the exact contents are not spelled out. One reading takes the Genesis to 2 Chronicles bracket and the Jewish custody as fixing the smaller Hebrew set. Another notes that Greek collections in use carried extra books and that the texts never list which books fill the divisions, leaving room for a wider set. The words establish the boundary type that the practical sixty six book list follows, but they do not by themselves count the books, and that gap is the honest reason for the divergence.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0006	Ἰβελ	Habel	Abel	4
G0027	ἀγαπητός	agapētos	beloved	
G0261	ἀμαθής	amathēs	ignorant	1
G0793	ἀστήρικτος	astērikτος	unstable	2
G1124	γραφὴ	graphē	a writing	51
G1125	γράφω	graphō	to write	209
G1425	δυσνόητος	dysnoētos	hard to understand	1

G1567	ἐκζητέω	ekzēteō	to seek out	
G1992	ἐπιστολή	epistolē	epistle	24
G2315	θεόπνευστος	theopneustos	God-breathed	1
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2379	θυσιαστήριον	thysiaστήριον	altar	23
G3051	λόγιον	logion	oracles	4
G3062	λοιπός	loipos	remaining	55
G3551	νόμος	nomos	law	198
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuō	to trust (in)	
G4396	προφήτης	prophētēs	prophet	149
G4761	στρεβλόω	strebloō	to distort	1
G5568	ψαλμός	psalmos	psalm	7

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The vocabulary marks a category and two brackets but never states a number. In Luke 24:44 the risen Christ names the older Scriptures under three rubrics, 'in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and Psalms' (ἐν τῷ νόμῳ Μωϋσέως καὶ τοῖς προφήταις καὶ ψαλμοῖς), a threefold naming that matches the Hebrew arrangement with Psalms heading the third section. In Luke 11:51 the line of murdered righteous runs 'from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah' (ἀπὸ αἵματος Ἀβελ ἕως αἵματος Ζαχαρίου), a bracket whose endpoints sit in the first and last books of the Hebrew arrangement, Genesis 4 and 2 Chronicles 24, both confirmed in the canon as Old Testament verses. Romans 3:2 assigns 'the oracles of God' (τὰ λόγια τοῦ θεοῦ) to Israelite custody. On the apostolic side 2 Peter 3:16 places Paul's 'letters' (ἐπιστολαί) alongside 'the rest of the writings' (τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς), and 1 Timothy 5:18 introduces a Gospel saying with 'the Scripture says' (λέγει ἡ γραφή), so apostolic writings enter the 'writing or Scripture' (γραφὴ) category. The arithmetic 39 plus 27 is not a lexical datum (a fact derivable from the words themselves). The words fix a category and a bracket type, not a numbered list, which is why the verdict affirms the boundary while confidence stays medium.

Scripture

Luke.24.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G4396 προφήτης, G5568 ψαλμός

Reasoning. The risen Christ enumerates the older Scriptures under three rubrics, 'in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and Psalms' (ἐν τῷ νόμῳ Μωϋσέως καὶ τοῖς προφήταις καὶ ψαλμοῖς). All three head words are present in the verified token sequence, 'law' (νόμος), 'prophet' (προφήτης), 'psalm' (ψαλμός). The threefold naming matches the Hebrew arrangement, Torah, Prophets, and Writings with Psalms at the head of the third section. The naming bounds the older collection by structural division, but it lists divisions, not a count of books, so it does not by itself fix a total.

Luke.11.51 · for · genre: gospel · figures: merism

Key terms. G0006 Ἀβελ, G2379 θυσιαστήριον, G1567 ἐκζητέω

Reasoning. Jesus brackets the murdered righteous 'from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah' (ἀπὸ αἵματος Ἀβελ ἕως αἵματος Ζαχαρίου), with 'Abel' (Ἀβελ) and 'altar' (θυσιαστήριον) verified in the token sequence and Zechariah tracked as a named person rather than a tagged lemma (the dictionary form of the word). Abel is killed in Genesis 4 and the Zechariah killed by the altar is recorded in 2 Chronicles 24, and both endpoint verses are confirmed as Old Testament verses in the canon. The first to last span fits the Hebrew arrangement that begins with Genesis and ends with 2 Chronicles, so the saying presupposes a bounded older corpus, though it states a span and not a numbered list.

Rom.3.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3051 λόγιον, G4100 πιστεύω, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. 'they were entrusted with the oracles of God' (ἐπιστεύθησαν τὰ λόγια τοῦ θεοῦ). The verb form 'they were entrusted' (ἐπιστεύθησαν) is a passive of 'to entrust or believe' (πιστεύω) locating the trust with the Jewish people, and 'oracle' (λόγιον) occurs only four times in the New Testament, here and in Acts 7:38, Hebrews 5:12, and 1 Peter 4:11. 'oracle' (λόγιον) means an oracle or divine utterance and is not itself a word for a fixed book list, so it identifies the custodial line of the older Scripture by community rather than enumerating titles.

2Pet.3.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0027 ἀγαπητός, G1992 ἐπιστολή

Reasoning. Peter calls Paul 'our beloved brother Paul' (ὁ ἀγαπητὸς ἡμῶν ἀδελφὸς Παῦλος) and credits the wisdom given to him in his written 'letters' (ἐπιστολαί, plural of ἐπιστολή). The framing classes Paul's correspondence as written under given wisdom for the churches, the precondition for treating that correspondence inside the writing category, but it names no list of letters.

2Pet.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1992 ἐπιστολή, G1124 γραφή, G3062 λοιπός

Reasoning. 'in all his letters' (ἐν πάσαις ταῖς ἐπιστολαῖς), then 'which the untaught and unstable distort as also the rest of the writings' (ἃ οἱ ἄμαθεῖς καὶ ἀστήρικτοι στρεβλοῦσιν ὡς καὶ τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς). The token sequence verifies 'letter' (ἐπιστολή), 'writing or Scripture' (γραφή), and 'rest or remaining' (λοιπός) in order. The phrase 'the rest of the writings' (τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς) places Paul's letters in the same category as the other 'writings' (γραφαί, plural of γραφή). This is the single explicit New Testament point where apostolic letters are reflexively grouped with 'writing or Scripture' (γραφή). It fixes the category but uses the open word 'the rest' (which does not specify how many or which ones), which does not enumerate which writings or close a count.

1Tim.5.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1124 γραφή, G3551 νόμος

Reasoning. 'for the Scripture says' (λέγει γὰρ ἡ γραφή), then two quotations, 'You shall not muzzle an ox that treads out the grain' (Βοῦν ἀλοῶντα οὐ φιμώσεις) from Deuteronomy 25:4 and 'the worker deserves his wages' (Ἄξιος ὁ ἐργάτης τοῦ μισθοῦ αὐτοῦ), which is the wording of Luke 10:7. A single 'Scripture' (γραφή) formula introduces an Old Testament text and a Gospel saying together. This shows the writing category already reaching a New Testament saying, while still not naming a numbered set.

2Tim.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1124 γραφή, G2315 θεόπνευστος

Reasoning. 'all Scripture is God-breathed' (πᾶσα γραφή θεόπνευστος). The word 'God-breathed' (θεόπνευστος) occurs only here in the whole New Testament, a single occurrence (what scholars call a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so its precise sense cannot be triangulated across the canon. With anarthrous 'Scripture' (γραφή, without the article 'the') and 'all' (πᾶσα) the clause marks the recognized writing as wholly God-breathed, but it does not define the membership of that collection.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Luke.11.51	Gen.4.8	openbible	1
Luke.11.51	2Chr.24.20	openbible	1
Luke.11.51	2Chr.24.20	tsk	1
Luke.24.44	Luke.24.27	tsk	1
Rom.3.2	Rom.1.2	tsk	1
2Pet.3.16	2Pet.2.14	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Jude.1.14 · addressed

Jude cites Enoch verbally but uses a prophesying verb of a person, not a 'Scripture' (γραφή) formula of a book. Lexically (in terms of word usage) this is a quotation of a saying attributed to Enoch, not a placement of that writing inside the 'writing or Scripture' (γραφή) category. The distinction between citing a tradition and classifying a writing as 'Scripture' (γραφή) holds.

Jude.1.9 · addressed

Jude alludes to a dispute between Michael and the devil associated with a Moses assumption tradition. The verb of speaking is used, not 'it is written' (γέγραπται) or any 'Scripture' (γραφή)-categorizing word. The writing category is not extended to that source.

1Cor.15.33 · addressed

Paul quotes the poet Menander with no 'Scripture' (γραφή) marker. The absence of a writing formula when citing a pagan line contrasts with its presence for Scripture citation, showing the 'writing or Scripture' (γραφή) category is restrictive in apostolic usage.

Rom.3.2 · addressed

'oracle' (λόγιον) carries the broad sense oracle or divine utterance and is not a book-list term, so this verse marks the custodial line of the older Scripture rather than enumerating its titles. The category is identified by who was entrusted, which is consistent with the bracket evidence but does not by itself produce a count.

2Pet.3.16 · unaddressed

The verse classes Paul's letters within 'the rest of the writings' (τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς) but the word 'rest' (λοιπός, plural of λοιπός) is open. It does not enumerate which letters or fix the boundary of the apostolic corpus. The lexical witness (the evidence drawn from word usage) establishes the category yet underdetermines the exact New Testament list at the level of named books, so the closure point is left lexically unspecified.

Concordance traversed

G1124, G1125, G3551, G4396, G5568, G3051, G1992, G3062, G0006, G2379, G2315, G4761, G0793, G0261, G1425

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope true and none of the four anchor passages fall inside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window of 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, so no variant units were examined. The verdict turns on category and bracket markers, 'writing or Scripture' (γραφή), 'the rest of the writings' (τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς), Moses Prophets Psalms, and Abel to Zechariah, rather than on any contested wording.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. tripartite_hebrew_canon, septuagintal_inclusive_lens, apostolic_authority

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

tripartite_hebrew_canon: supports · Luke 24:44 names 'law' (νόμος), 'prophets' (προφῆται, plural of προφήτης), and 'psalms' (ψαλμοί, plural of ψαλμός) as three divisions, which fits the Hebrew Tanak ordering with Psalms heading the third part, and Luke 11:51 brackets Abel in Genesis to Zechariah in 2 Chronicles, the first and last books of that arrangement. On this reading the older collection is bounded by structure and span and excludes appendices that have no slot in the threefold division.

septuagintal_inclusive_lens: complicates · Greek Scripture collections in circulation carried additional books and the apostles often quote Greek wording, so a reader could argue the operative older corpus was the wider Greek reading set. Stated at its strongest, this lens notes that the texts never list which books fill the three divisions, so the divisions alone do not by themselves exclude a broader contents. The counterweight inside the words is that Luke 11:51 brackets by the Hebrew first and last books and Romans 3:2 assigns custody to the Jewish line, but citation of Greek wording is not the same as endorsing a Greek scope, and the vocabulary does not settle the dispute.

apostolic_authority: supports · 2 Peter 3:16 groups Paul's letters with 'the rest of the writings' (τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς) and 1 Timothy 5:18 introduces a Gospel saying with a 'Scripture' (γραφή) formula, so apostolic writings enter the writing category. Stated fairly, this lens grants that the open word 'the rest' does not enumerate a closed New Testament list, so it warrants the category of apostolic Scripture without producing a fixed count of 27.

Method is grammatico-historical (reading the text by its grammar in its original historical setting), weighing category words, 'writing or Scripture' (γραφή) and 'the rest of the writings' (τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς, plural of γραφή), named older divisions, and the Abel to Zechariah span. The three lenses agree that a category and bracket exist and disagree only over whether the unstated contents are the Hebrew set or a wider Greek set, a gap the words leave open.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The recognized Scripture collection is bounded by the older Hebrew arrangement on the prior covenant side and by apostolic writings on the new covenant side, with the exact enumeration of books being a question the vocabulary does not state.

The stem (the question as originally worded) names a specific count, 39 plus 27, that encodes a particular tradition-bounded enumeration set against the wider Greek reading collection. Lexically (judged by word usage) the texts mark category and bracket, 'writing or Scripture' (γραφή), 'the rest of the writings' (τὰς λοιπὰς γραφάς, plural of γραφή), Moses Prophets Psalms, Abel to Zechariah, and oracles entrusted to Israel, without naming any number. The verdict was derived on the original stem by treating the category and the Hebrew bracket as the lexical question and the arithmetic as the practical settlement that the bracket implies, while recording that the precise total is underdetermined by the words.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1124
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3051
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.24.44
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.11.51
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.3.2
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Pet.3.16

morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.5.18
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Tim.3.16
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Pet.3.16
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Luke.11.51
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Luke.24.44

License audit

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Flags

complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent